ALPRAZOLAM

High dependence & misuse

Controlled drug

CHEMICAL NAME 8-chloro-1-methyl-6-phenyl-4H-[1,2,4]triazolo[4,3-a][1,4]benzodiazepine

CLASS Short-to-intermediate-acting triazolobenzodiazepine

TRADE NAMES Xanax · Xanax XR · Alprax · Niravam

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Short-term treatment of anxiety disorders.
- Panic disorder (with or without agoraphobia).

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** 2–3 times daily (IR) or once daily (XR, swallow whole).
- Shortest duration possible (2–4 weeks); taper very slowly.

DOSAGES

- **Anxiety:** 0.25–0.5 mg three times daily; max 4 mg/day.
- **Panic disorder:** 0.5 mg 2–3 times daily, up to 3–6 mg/day (specialist).
- **Elderly/hepatic impairment:** 0.25 mg 2–3 times daily.
- Taper by ≤0.5 mg every 3 days.

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Onset:** 30–60 min; peak 1–2 h. **Duration:** 4–6 h (IR).
- Metabolised by CYP3A4.
- Excreted in urine. **t½:** 11–15 h.

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- **GABA-A** positive modulator → rapid anxiolysis; some antidepressant-like effect.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Drowsiness, sedation.
- Dizziness, impaired coordination.
- Memory problems, dry mouth.

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- Dependence, interdose rebound anxiety, severe withdrawal (seizures) — higher than long-acting benzos.
- Respiratory depression with opioids/alcohol.
- Paradoxical disinhibition; falls.

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Respiratory depression, sleep apnoea, myasthenia gravis.
- Severe hepatic impairment.
- Use with ketoconazole/itraconazole.
- Acute narrow-angle glaucoma.

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **Ketoconazole, itraconazole, ritonavir:** contraindicated (↑↑ levels).
- **Fluvoxamine, macrolides, grapefruit:** ↑ levels.
- **Opioids, alcohol:** ↑ CNS depression.

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Assess anxiety, sedation, misuse risk.
- Limit supply and duration; plan taper.
- Fall precautions in elderly.
- Encourage psychological therapies (CBT).

PATIENT EDUCATION

- For short-term use; dependence develops quickly.
- Never stop suddenly; taper with your doctor.
- Avoid alcohol and driving.
- Keep medication secure.

KEY POINTS

- Short-acting benzo for anxiety/panic.
- High dependence and withdrawal risk.
- 0.25–0.5 mg TDS.
- CYP3A4 interactions.

SOURCES CHECKED [756] Xanax 250 microgram Tablets (UK SmPC) [757] Alprazolam, oral (US label) [758] Alprazolam, oral (US label, Par Health USA)

Full references p. 432–457